

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 33

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A young choir soloist describes the moment she froze on her opening note at a school concert.

1

The school hall had been warm all afternoon, but the moment Mr Tan raised his baton the air seemed to thin and go cold. From where I stood, half a pace in front of the choir, I could see the parents in the front row leaning slightly forward, the way people lean when they are about to be polite about something. My mother, third from the aisle, gave me the small private smile she had given me at every audition since I was nine. The piano played four bars of introduction. On the fifth, I was to sing.

2

I knew the note. I had known it for eleven weeks. It was a B flat, lifted just above middle C, and I had taken it cleanly in every rehearsal, including the run-through that morning. Yet when the introduction folded its final chord into the silence, and Mr Tan's eyes met mine across the music stand, my throat closed. Not partly. Entirely. I opened my mouth and produced, instead of a B flat, a very small and very embarrassing nothing.

3

There is, I have since learned, a particular quality to silence in a school hall when a soloist has failed to come in. It is not the ordinary silence of an audience waiting; it is a silence that sharpens, as if the room itself has noticed. A child somewhere coughed. A chair creaked. I felt the heat rise from my collar to the roots of my hair. I could not look at my mother. I could not look at Mr Tan. I looked, instead, at the line of black tape on the floor where my shoes were meant to be, and I willed the tape to swallow me.

4

Mr Tan did not stop. He did not even sigh. He simply gave the smallest nod — so small that I think only the front row of the choir saw it — and on the next beat, very gently, the altos behind me began the opening line that had been mine. A bar later, the sopranos joined. Their voices were softer than they should have been; they were carrying me, the way one carries a child across a stream, careful not to wake

her. I stood absolutely still in the middle of their sound, and for several seconds I could not tell whether I was about to cry or to laugh.

5

What I felt then was not, I think, gratitude. Gratitude came later. What I felt at that moment was something closer to disbelief — that two dozen people who had every reason to be furious with me had instead chosen, in the space of half a beat, to cover for my failure. I had not asked for this. I did not deserve it. And yet there it was, in the quiet voices of girls I had teased in the canteen and boys I had barely spoken to: a small and unfussy mercy, offered without comment.

6

At the end of the first verse, Mr Tan turned a single page on his music stand. He did not look at me. He simply lifted his baton again, breathed in, and gave me the cue for the second verse — the same cue, the same calm hand. This time I sang. My voice was thin in the first phrase, and trembled a little in the second, but it was there, and the choir, who had been holding the music for me, stepped a half-step back to let it through.

7

We finished the piece. There was applause, of the warm and slightly relieved kind that audiences offer when a thing has not gone perfectly but has gone well enough. I bowed with the others. I did not look at my mother until we had filed off the stage, and when I finally did, she was not crying, as I had feared, but laughing — quietly, with her hand over her mouth — at something my younger brother had whispered into her ear. The world, I realised, had not ended.

8

I sang many solos after that, in halls larger and stranger than ours, and I have frozen on stage exactly once more, in a city whose name I will not give. Each time, I have thought of Mr Tan's nod and of the altos behind me. I have come to understand that there is a difference between failing and falling, and that the difference is often made by the people standing closest to you. To fail is to come apart in public. To fall is only to come down for a moment, and to be caught.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator notices that the parents were “leaning slightly forward, the way people lean when they are about to be polite about something.” What does this comparison suggest about her impression of the audience? [2]

2. The narrator says the air in the hall “seemed to thin and go cold” the moment the conductor raised his baton. What does this suggest about her **state of mind** at that moment? [1]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says her throat closed “Not partly. Entirely.” Explain how the **short sentences** used here add to the effect of the description. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator describes the silence in the hall as one that “sharpens, as if the room itself has noticed.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison tells us about her experience of the silence. [2]

5. Give **two** small physical details from Paragraph 3 that show how acutely embarrassed the narrator was. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator says the other singers “were carrying me, the way one carries a child across a stream, careful not to wake her.” Explain what is **effective** about this comparison. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator describes what the choir did as “a small and unfussy mercy, offered without comment.”

- (a) Explain what the word **unfussy** suggests about the way the choir helped her. [1]
(b) Why does the narrator find it surprising that the choir helped her? [1]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator says the choir “stepped a half-step back to let it through” when she began to sing. Explain, in your own words, what the choir was doing for her at this moment. [2]

From Paragraph 7

9. The narrator had feared that her mother would be crying, but found her laughing quietly instead. What does this contrast suggest about how the narrator had been imagining the situation? [2]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator writes that “there is a difference between failing and falling.” Explain, in your own words, what she means by this distinction. [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the cultural meaning of national anthems and whether they still belong in a globalised world.

1

Almost every nation on earth has one, and almost no one stops to think where it came from. The national anthem — that brief, often stirring piece of music played before football matches, at school assemblies, and at the opening of parliaments — feels, to most listeners, as old as the country it represents. In fact, the great majority of anthems are surprisingly young. Most were composed in the nineteenth century, in the high tide of European romantic nationalism, and were imitated, often within a single generation, by newly independent states elsewhere. The form is barely two hundred years old; the feeling it provokes is older than that, but the music that channels it is, in historical terms, almost new.

2

What anthems actually do, however, is not really to teach history. They do something simpler and stranger. A good anthem, played at the right moment, takes a crowd of unrelated strangers — people who would not, on any other day, agree about anything — and persuades them, for ninety seconds, to feel one thing together. The hand goes to the chest; the eyes lift; the voice, if the listener is brave, joins in. Sociologists have a clumsy phrase for this: “collective emotion.” Anyone who has stood in a stadium during a well-sung anthem knows it by a shorter and more honest name.

3

This power is precisely what makes anthems so frequently uncomfortable. A surprising number of national anthems contain lyrics that, read coolly in the morning, are unmistakably violent. France’s “Marseillaise” speaks of impure blood watering the fields. Several Latin American anthems were written, in essence, as battle songs against a colonial power, and their original texts still call for the spilling of that power’s blood. Other anthems were composed during colonial periods themselves, and contain assumptions about empire and racial hierarchy that modern citizens find painful to sing. In recent years, several countries — among them New Zealand, South Africa and Canada — have quietly revised offending lines, or added verses in indigenous languages, in an effort to bring the words into the present.

4

The setting in which anthems are most often heard today is not, in fact, the battlefield. It is the sports event. Before international fixtures, the anthems of the two competing nations are played in turn, and the cameras linger, with a kind of devotional attention, on the faces of the players. Some sing; some weep; some stand impassively. The ritual is so familiar that we forget how peculiar it is: two nations who are, by treaty and trade, at peace, agreeing for ninety seconds to behave as though something larger than sport were about to take place. It is, in many ways, a substitute for the older, bloodier confrontations that international gatherings used to involve.

5

Critics, of whom there are many, argue that the whole exercise has begun to feel dated. We live, they say, in a globalised world: footballers play in foreign leagues, students study in foreign universities, and consumers buy from companies whose nationality is little more than a tax arrangement. To insist, at this moment, on a piece of music that asserts the uniqueness and dignity of a single nation is, the argument runs, to look determinedly backwards. Some have proposed regional anthems — a European one, an African Union one — or even an anthem for the United Nations, played at suitable global occasions. None of these proposals has caught on. The reason, most likely, is that the emotion an anthem produces is not really about the world; it is about the small, specific country in which one happened to be born or chose to settle.

6

There is also a defence of anthems that has nothing to do with nationalism in the aggressive sense. A good anthem, sung properly, is one of the very few occasions in modern life on which large numbers of unrelated people sing together at all. Communal singing, once common in churches, schools and workplaces, has retreated; the anthem is, for many citizens, the last remaining occasion when they raise their voice in a public chorus. To abolish the practice on the grounds that it is old-fashioned would be to remove, without replacement, a rare and democratic form of shared expression.

7

What seems likely is that anthems will continue to evolve rather than disappear. Lyrics will be revised; offensive verses will be retired; new languages will be added; tunes themselves, in a few cases, will be rewritten. The basic ritual, however — a crowd of strangers, standing still, briefly persuaded to feel one thing together — has proved remarkably durable. In a century that prizes individual choice above almost everything, the willingness of a stadium to fall silent for a piece of music is, perhaps, more interesting than it first appears. It suggests that the desire to belong to something larger than oneself has not been globalised away. It has merely been waiting, like the music, for its cue.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that anthems feel “as old as the country” they represent, but most are in fact “surprisingly young.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means here. [2]

13. According to Paragraph 1, what historical movement gave rise to most national anthems? [1]

From Paragraph 2

14. The writer says a good anthem persuades a crowd of strangers “to feel one thing together.” What does the writer suggest is **unusual** or **surprising** about this effect? [2]

15. The writer describes “collective emotion” as a “clumsy phrase.” What does the writer suggest is **better** than this academic phrase, and why? [1]

From Paragraph 3

16. Give **two** reasons, from Paragraph 3, why national anthems are sometimes “uncomfortable” to sing today. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that playing anthems at sports events is “a substitute for the older, bloodier confrontations” between nations. Explain, in your own words, what this suggests about the role of sport in modern international life. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer reports that proposals for regional or global anthems have “not caught on.” What reason does the writer give for this? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer claims that the anthem is “the last remaining occasion when [citizens] raise their voice in a public chorus.” Explain why the writer believes this is a **valuable** feature of the practice. [2]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer says that the desire to belong “has not been globalised away. It has merely been waiting, like the music, for its cue.” What is **effective** about ending the article with this image? [2]

21. What is the writer’s overall **attitude** towards the future of national anthems? [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **what national anthems actually do for those who hear them**, and **the criticisms that are now made of national anthems**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 5** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

When played at the right moment, a national anthem ...

— END OF PAPER —